

Dvar Torah Outline — Maharal (Perek Tefillah, Closeness to Hashem, and :סד Layers of Divine Rescue

Abstract

This dvar Torah (learning through the Maharal on a Midrash) develops a central idea: Hashem's "hearing" of Jewish prayer is not incidental, but a defining expression of ישראל's closeness to Him. It then maps a progression of salvation—Hashem sustains good times, rescues in crisis, protects even when we don't cry out, and even helps when we are spiritually or behaviorally "passive." Finally, it interprets a three-part verse ("death," "tears," "stumbling") as three increasingly subtle levels of rescue, showing that Hashem's care extends beyond life-and-death to weakening and even minor pain.

I. "Only Israel has 'ears'": what it means that Hashem hears us

A. The Maharal's claim

- "אין האזניים קרויות אלא לישראל"
 - The "ears" (i.e., being *heard*) are uniquely associated with ישראל.
 - This is presented as "דבר מופלג מאוד בחכמה" — a deep and far-reaching idea.

B. "When am I beloved?" — prayer being heard as the sign of belovedness

- (I love, because Hashem hears) "אהבתי כי ישמע ה"
 - Interpreted as: "אהוב לפני הקדוש ברוך הוא" — I am beloved when Hashem hears my prayer.
- Key point:
 - Hashem hearing/accepting tefillah is not random kindness; it reflects relationship and closeness.

C. Closeness as the reason tefillah is accepted

- Quoted verse:
 - “אֲשֶׁר לוֹ אֱלֹהִים קְרִיבִים אֵלָיו כֹּה' אֱלֹהֵינוּ בְּכָל־קְרָאנוּ אֵלָיו” (“For who is a great nation that has God close to it like Hashem our God whenever we call to Him?”)
 - Emphasis:
 - “קבלה” (acceptance of prayer) is linked to “קְרִיבָה” (closeness).
 - ישראל's closeness is uniquely expressed “בכל קראנו אליו.”
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II. What does “close” mean if Hashem has no spatial distance?

A. The question

- If Hashem is not physical, what does it mean to be “close” or “far” from Him?

B. Suggested definitions of closeness

- **Similarity / likeness:**
 - The more aligned one is, the more “close.”
- **Primacy in creation / alignment with רצון ה':**
 - Not “similar to אין סוף” in essence (impossible), but similar in terms of alignment with Hashem's will for creation.
 - ישראל is described as central to the purpose of creation in a way others are not

C. “Creator implies Provider”

- Analogy:
 - Parents bring a child into the world and therefore provide for the child's needs.
 - Application:
 - Hashem is “closer” to being *our* Creator (in purpose/relationship), therefore “closer” to being our Provider—expressed through answering prayer.
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III. “בימי אקרא” — tefillah specifically in good times

A. The line and its interpretation

- “בימי אקרא, אלו ימי טובה”
 - “Days” are read as “good days” (possibly contrasted with “night”).
 - Purpose:
 - When things are good, we daven to **extend** and **continue** that good:
 - “לזכור לה' להמשיך הטובה”
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IV. “אפפוני חבלי מות ומצרי שאול” — identifying the opponents

A. Two categories in the Midrash (as read by Maharal)

- “חבלי מות אלו הם רשעי ישראל”
 - “Ropes/bonds of death” = evil within Israel.
- “ומצרי שאול הם עכו”ם”
 - “Confinements of Sheol” = the nations (עכו”ם), described as “בעלי שאול.”

B. Noted difficulty in the presentation

- The speaker points out:
 - Maharal says “כך הבנתי מדברי רבותינו ז”ל במדרש” — phrased with less confidence.
 - Maharal does not cite the Midrash explicitly in the text (later identified as part of the same Yalkut Shimoni context being learned).

C. Conceptual distinction: “מות” vs. “שאול”

- Proposed difference:
 - **מות**: death (a stage).
 - **שאול**: grave / a deeper “already-there” state; also connotes an aspect of גיהנום.
 - نتیجه:
 - Even a רשע מ ישראל is “חבלי מות,” but “מצרי שאול” implies a more entrenched קשר to שאול/גיהנום.
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V. “אנא ה' מלטה נפשי” — why the tzaddik needs rescue

A. Tzaddikim as those who escape Gehinom

- “ומפני שהצדיקים נמלטים ונושעים מן הגיהנום”
 - The tzaddik's defining feature: separation from גיהנום (as “lack of existence”).

B. The opponents: “בעלי גיהנום”

- “ומתנגדם האלו הם בעלי גיהנום”
 - Those opposing the tzaddik are identified as connected to Gehinom.
- Dynamic:
 - They attempt to “reach” the tzaddik and pull him down.
 - Hashem “מעלה את הצדיקים מן הגיהנום” — elevates and rescues them so the אנשי שאול cannot access them.

C. The greatness: transcendence

- “והוא מעלה גדולה לצדיקים”
 - Being beyond Gehinom is framed as spiritual transcendence (נבדל מן הגיהנום).

VI. “חנן ה' וצדיק ואלוקינו מרחם” — two situations, two Divine modes

A. Returning to the two earlier themes

1. “בימי אקרא” — calling out in good times.
2. **Crisis opposition** — “אפפוני חבלי מות...”

B. “חנן ה' וצדיק” — continuing goodness in good times

- “חנן”
 - Hashem gives good even when not fully deserved.
- “וצדיק”
 - Hashem as “charitable” / acting with צדקה.
- Function:
 - “להמשיך הטובה” — to keep the good flowing.

C. “ואלוקינו מרחם” — mercy in harsh, דין-based conditions

- “אלוקינו”
 - מידת הדין.
 - “מרחם”
 - Hashem sees the צרה and softens it through mercy.
 - Point:
 - In מלחמה / harsh times, the language shifts to דין—but mercy operates there too.
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VII. Beyond answered prayer: Hashem protects even without our awareness

A. “שומר פתאים” — protection when we don’t even call out

- “ויוסף מזה אף שאיני אקרא... שומר פתאים”
 - Even if I’m not alert to the danger, Hashem guards me.
- The חסד grows:
 - Rescue is not only “responsive” to tefillah; it can be proactive.

B. “דלותי ולי הושיע” — salvation even when impoverished in mitzvot

- Midrashic reading:
 - “אף שאני דל מן המצוות... לי נאה להושיע”
- Suggested association:
 - Echoes themes of ישראל lacking merits/mitzvot yet still redeemed.
- Core message:
 - The relationship is so foundational that Hashem saves even amid spiritual deficiency.

C. Even when passive and “too comfortable”

- “ויוסף מזה שאני יושב בטל ובמנוחה”
 - Even when I am inactive, relaxed, wasting time.
 - Conclusion line:
 - “שובי נפשי למנוחייכי כי ה' גמל עלייכי”
 - Hashem “גומל חסד” even then.
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VIII. כי חלצת נפשי ממות... את עיני מן דמעה... את” three levels of rescue — “רגלי מדחי”

A. Identifying the three terms

- death — “מות”
- tears — “דמעה”
- being pushed/stumbled/knocked off balance — “דחי”

B. A descending scale: from total destruction to mild pain

1. “חלצת נפשי ממות”

- Full rescue from death itself.

2. “את עיני מן דמעה”

- Tears as “אפיסת כוח” (*a weakening / functional shutdown*).
- Even if it’s “not death,” it’s still a form of collapse that Hashem prevents.

3. “את רגלי מדחי”

- “צער בעלמא” (*pain/disruption without incapacitation*).
- Hashem protects even from “stumbling” level suffering.

C. The theological takeaway

- Hashem’s care is not only about saving life.
- It extends to:
 - preventing emotional collapse,
 - and even shielding from lesser forms of distress.

IX. Summary points

- Hashem “hearing” תפילה s'ישראל is a manifestation of unique closeness: **“אֲשֶׁר לוֹ אֱלֹהִים קְרִיבִים אֵלָיו...”**
- “Closeness” is defined non-spatially: alignment with רצון ה' and centrality in creation.
- The Midrashic reading distinguishes threats:
 - “חבלי מות” (רשעי ישראל) vs. “מצרי שאול” (עכו"ם / אנשי שאול).
- Hashem’s salvation escalates in generosity:
 - sustains good → rescues in crisis → protects even without being called → saves even amid spiritual/behavioral passivity.

- The threefold verse teaches that Hashem rescues on every level: **death**, **weakening**, and **mere pain/stumbling**.